Three Crises: The Pandemic, China and Russia

The Covid-19 pandemic which began in Wuhan, China, in late 2019 but spread rapidly around the world over the next year, was a watershed moment in many respects. India was deemed particularly vulnerable, given its economy and public health infrastructure. India responded by quickly issuing a nation-wide lockdown, one which initially mitigated the spread of the disease, but which had major implications for the economy. Emergency efforts at manufacturing basic supplies at scale—including pharmaceuticals, medical devices, and personal protective equipment—underscored the vulnerability of supply chains and the need for domestic manufacturing capability. India also undertook a massive repatriation mission, bringing stranded Indians back home, an exercise that would prove useful in other humanitarian and disaster relief contingencies. Initially, India was deemed to have fared relatively well as many countries in Europe, West Asia, and the Americas fared poorly, with large numbers of infections and deaths. But this optimism proved premature. The rapid spread of the Delta variant of the pandemic in India in 2021 had devastating consequences. From previously providing pandemic supplies to the rest of the world, India focused on the emergency sourcing of oxygen concentrators and other supplies. Over the following years, the race to vaccinate and document vaccinations took precedence, as multiple waves of the pandemic continued to spread around the world.

The pandemic contributed, at least in part, to another shock in the spring of 2020. Forces of China's People's Liberation Army (PLA), initially in the process of conducting scheduled military exercises in Tibet, deployed rapidly at a number of forward points along the disputed Western Sector of the Line of Actual Control (LAC) in Ladakh. The four main friction points were (north to south) the Galwan Valley, Hot Springs, Gogra, and the north bank of Pangong Tso, with further disagreements in the far north at Depsang and in south-east Ladakh at Demchok. [36] In contrast to border stand-offs in 2013, 2014, and 2017, Chinese forces deployed in far larger numbers with full armaments (including armour and artillery) and logistical